



BHALOTIA'S TRAINEES
TAKE GOLF TO KOLKATA'S
BACKSTREETS

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is not a problem."

So what is called Vision 2014 took off with about 20 children from Ek Prayaas. Aged between eight to 14, they attend their golf classes at the Calcutta Ladies Golf Club course at the Maidan every Friday after school. Bhalotia believes that scouting the lowest strata of society is the best bet to hunt for talent in golf. Gaurav Ghosh, Indian Golf Union Council member and in-charge of junior training in East Zone, agrees. "If one gets proper training, it doesn't really matter which strata of society one comes from. These are young kids eager to learn. We may get a Chowrasia from here, or maybe someone a lot better."

What makes this project, dedicated to Bhalotia's mother Shyamali, special is the appreciation from the children. "They are much more enthusiastic and intense than many of those who come from more fortunate backgrounds," he says. Which is almost the entire population of golf players belonging to rarefied clubs.

The children are given free training, equipment, kit and a meal. There is also a future plan: when the most gifted golf players are found from these children, they will be involved in a sponsored programme and given the support a player needs to move to a higher level. Bhalotia is confident that national champions will emerge

SSP CHOWRASIA, ONE OF INDIA'S GOLF PROS, SAYS UNDER- PRIVILEGED CHILDREN COULD TOUCH THE SKY IF THEY ARE GIVEN PROPER TRAINING.

from his bunch. The project may only involve children from one school, but it is directed towards all children from under-privileged backgrounds. Bhalotia and his team are ready to take on about 200. "Golf is a good career option these days. Why not give these children a chance to get a shot at a better life?" says Bhalotia.

Indian golf has several caddies working their way through the ranks to earn a name. Last year, Kolkata's own SSP Chowrasia won the single biggest pay cheque given to an athlete in India—Rs 1.6 crore—when he won the Emaar-MGF Indian Masters, the first European PGA event in the country. Last month, C. Muniyappa, a caddie who grew up near the Karnataka Golf Association course where his father worked as a labourer, won the Indian Open, the biggest golf event in the country, and Rs 92 lakh as the winner's prize.

Chowrasia is all praise for this programme as he compares his training days when they learnt by watching with what these children are getting. "There is a lot of talent among these children and they are being trained by a good coach. I don't see why they can't become great players if I could." He adds, "You will find such projects abroad which churns up talent. And if I can contribute in any way, I will definitely help."

Eleven-year-old Tanishka epitomises this optimism. The young girl had an open heart surgery (aided by Ek Prayaas and sponsored by Rotary) a couple of years ago. From being perennially sick to being an active child, Tanishka has shown a grit that makes champions. "I love to play. Sir (Bhalotia) is very nice. I want to be a champion one day," she says.

Fourteen-year-old Mohammed Nasir Alam is the big brother of the programme. A fan of Tiger Woods, he practises his swing with an intense expression. Raju Chowdhury, 11, swears by football but he loves the new game too. Sarita Salma, Musqan Bibi, Mohammed Sarfaraz, Saif Shams, S.K. Raj—the children rattle off their names and share stories. A trip to Royal Calcutta Golf Club, the second oldest golf club in the world and India's most holy, has heightened their desire to find a better life away from the drudgery of their day-to-day existence at home where even a meal a day is not guaranteed.

Donna Dickson, the principal of Ek Prayaas, says the golf class helps the children feel "they are being given a special chance and are already thinking of becoming champions one day." The organisation has about 130 children in the age group of four to 15 who study up to Standard V here to be part of the mainstream rather than being forced to become victims of child labour or even worse.

A traditionally elitist sport bringing a spark to the lives of underprivileged children is an achievement in itself. If India gets a national champion from these ranks, then that would be a bonus indeed. ■